

Guide for Students: Accessing MongoDB Atlas Free Tier via the GitHub Student Developer Pack

Introduction

MongoDB Atlas is a cloud database service that offers a generous free tier suited for learning and small-scale projects. Students can further enhance their experience by leveraging the GitHub Student Developer Pack, which provides \ \$50 in Atlas credits and additional benefits. This guide explains how to qualify for the student pack, redeem the credits, and deploy a free M0 cluster on MongoDB Atlas.

Step 1 – Apply for the GitHub Student Developer Pack

Confirm eligibility

The GitHub Student Developer Pack is open to **students 13 years or older** enrolled in a degree-granting educational program. Applicants must provide proof of current enrollment; a school-issued email address is preferred, but other documentation (such as a dated student ID or registration paper) can be used[1]. Students need a GitHub account to apply; those under 18 require parental consent.

Application process

1. Visit the [GitHub Education](#) page and click **Get benefits**. Select **Student** from the options.
2. If you have a school email address, verify it; otherwise upload alternative documentation showing you are currently enrolled[2].
3. Fill in the name of your school and a short description of how you plan to use GitHub[3]. Submit the form.
4. GitHub will review your application; once approved, you will receive access to the student pack.

The GitHub Student Developer Pack includes a MongoDB Student Program benefit providing \$50 in Atlas credits and a free certification course[4].

Step 2 – Redeem the MongoDB Student Pack

1. After receiving the GitHub Student Developer Pack, visit the [MongoDB for Students](#) page and sign in using your GitHub credentials.
2. Follow the prompts to claim your \ \$50 Atlas credit code and free certification. Credits expire **8–12 months** after claiming; once applied to an account, you have **12 months** to spend them[5].
3. **Important:** To apply the credit code to your Atlas account, you must enter a payment method (credit card or PayPal). This is required even if you plan to use only free clusters[6].
4. If you already have a MongoDB Atlas account, you can add the credit to your existing organization; you do **not** need to create a new account[5].

Step 3 – Create a MongoDB Atlas Account (if you do not have one)

1. Navigate to mongodb.com/cloud and click **Start free** or **Sign Up**.
2. Choose to sign up with **GitHub**, **Google**, or an email address. When registering with email, provide your email, first and last name, and a strong password. The password must be at least eight characters long and cannot contain your email or previously used passwords[7].

3. Accept MongoDB's Terms of Service and Privacy Policy, verify you are not a robot, and click **Sign up**[8].

Step 4 – Deploy a Free M0 Cluster

MongoDB Atlas offers a **free forever** M0 cluster that is ideal for learning and testing. Once you sign in to your Atlas organization:

1. **Select an organization and project** in Atlas, or create a new project.
2. Click **Create cluster**.
3. In the cluster creation wizard, select the **M0** option labeled *Free for ever*, which is specifically designed for development and proof-of-concept workloads[9].
4. Choose your **cloud provider** (AWS, Google Cloud, or Azure)[10] and select a **region** that supports M0 clusters[11].
5. Name your cluster. Cluster names must use only ASCII letters, numbers and hyphens, be ≤64 characters, and cannot be changed after deployment[12].
6. Click **Create**. Deployment can take up to **10 minutes**[13].

Step 5 – Create a Database User and Configure IP Access

1. After your cluster is ready, Atlas prompts you to **create a database user**. Enter a username and strong password and click **Create database user**[14]. The database user credentials are required to connect to your database.
2. Next, set up your **IP access list**. Click **Add My Current IP Address** to automatically whitelist your current IP, or manually enter other IP addresses that should be allowed to connect[15]. You can also allow access from anywhere for testing, but this is not recommended for production.

Step 6 – Connect to Your Cluster

1. Once the cluster is created and access configured, click **Connect**. Atlas will present options to connect via MongoDB Compass, the MongoDB Shell, or application drivers.
2. For application development, select **Connect your application**. Choose your driver and version, then copy the provided connection string. Replace <username> and <password> with the database user credentials you created.
3. Use this connection string in your code or tools (e.g., pymongo or Mongoose) to begin interacting with your free cluster.

Summary & Tips

- The GitHub Student Developer Pack allows students to claim \ \$50 in Atlas credits, which can be applied to paid cluster tiers or other Atlas services. Credits require a payment method and expire after about a year[6][5].
- Deploying a free M0 cluster does **not** consume your credits. It remains free and provides a small but functional environment for learning and testing[9].
- Always create secure database users and restrict IP access to prevent unauthorized connections[16].
- The student pack also includes a free MongoDB certification course; take advantage of this resource to deepen your knowledge.

By following these steps, students can leverage MongoDB Atlas's free tier and student benefits to build, deploy and experiment with cloud databases at zero cost.

[1] [2] [3] How to get the GitHub Student Developer Pack without a student ID - The GitHub Blog

<https://github.blog/developer-skills/career-growth/how-to-get-the-github-student-developer-pack-without-a-student-id/>

[4] Read and Write to a MongoDB Atlas Database in Minutes!

<https://news.mlh.io/read-and-write-to-a-mongodb-atlas-database-in-minutes-04-19-2023>

[5] Do I need new account to claim my student pack? - MongoDB for Academia / MongoDB for Students - MongoDB Developer Community Forums

<https://www.mongodb.com/community/forums/t/do-i-need-new-account-to-claim-my-student-pack/243533>

[6] MongoDB Student Pack

<https://www.mongodb.com/students>

[7] [8] Create an Atlas Account - Atlas - MongoDB Docs

<https://www.mongodb.com/docs/atlas/tutorial/create-atlas-account/>

[9] [10] [11] [12] [13] [14] [15] [16] Deploy a Free Cluster - Atlas - MongoDB Docs

<https://www.mongodb.com/docs/atlas/tutorial/deploy-free-tier-cluster/>